

PERSONAL RECOVERY PLANNING

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Establish a sustained recovery, free from addictive behaviors.
2. Establish and maintain total abstinence from addictive patterns while increasing knowledge of the disease of addiction and the process of recovery.
3. Begin thinking of recovery as something that involves every aspect of life and can be approached in a practical way.
4. Help in thinking about areas of life where problems may arise and preventing problems by planning for them or overcoming them more quickly if they do occur later in recovery.
5. Create a convenient list of people, groups, and techniques to lean on for support or information in times of distress.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE SUBSTANCE ABUSE/DEPENDENCE

- Alternative Methods for Managing Pain
- Alternatives to Addictive Behavior
- Balancing Recovery, Family, and Work
- Building My Support Network
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain
- Coping with Addiction and Mood Disorders or Bereavement
- Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Problems
- Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders
- Coping with Addiction and Thought Disorders
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Making Change Happen
- Planning Aftercare
- Problem Identification
- Relapse Prevention Planning
- Taking Daily Inventory

- Understanding Nonchemical Addictions
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using My Support Network
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Does Addiction Mean to Me?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Nicotine Dependence
- Opioid Dependence
- Relapse Proneness

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Personal Recovery Planning” activity is intended for a client who is at least somewhat motivated for recovery and needs structure and direction. It guides the client in identifying his/her goals for recovery to frame planning and strengthen motivation, then walks the client through several domains of life functioning, and prompts him/her to identify supportive resources and relationships and commit to a plan to use them. Follow-up for this exercise could include the activity titled “Relapse Prevention Planning,” keeping a journal on progress in carrying out the plan, and reporting back to the therapist, treatment group, and program sponsor on the outcomes of activities included in the personal recovery plan.

PERSONAL RECOVERY PLANNING

There are many ways to maintain a healthy lifestyle, free of self-defeating addictive behavior. Your recovery plan will be your own creation and will not be exactly like anyone else's. This exercise will give you a starting point and a framework to design your own program. It won't be a finished product when you are done—there will be more questions. It will provide you with a method you can fall back on when things get difficult and confusing.

1. When you think about your recovery, what do you want to accomplish? Above and beyond staying abstinent, some things many of us want to work toward include: control over our actions; self-respect and dignity; peace of mind; ability to enjoy life; the respect of others; improving our relationships; improved health; career progress; and improved finances. There are many others. Please list the five most important things on which you want to work.
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
 - c. _____
 - d. _____
 - e. _____
2. For each goal, please describe how a return to your addiction would affect your chances of getting what you want.
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
 - c. _____
 - d. _____
 - e. _____
3. For each goal, please describe how staying free of addictive behavior patterns will affect your chances of getting what you want.
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
 - c. _____
 - d. _____

- e. _____
4. For each goal, please list specifically what you want to accomplish (i.e., how you will know when you've achieved that goal).
- a. _____
- b. _____
- c. _____
- d. _____
- e. _____
5. For each goal, please list specific warning signs that would tell you if you were getting off track and heading for failure in achieving that goal.
- a. _____
- b. _____
- c. _____
- d. _____
- e. _____
6. Have you ever tried to cut back or completely quit your addiction(s) before? _____
- a. What methods were effective for you, if any? _____
- _____
- b. What methods were ineffective? _____
- _____
7. Success in staying out of addiction has both positive and negative parts: (1) finding *things to do* that work to help you remain abstinent, and (2) figuring out which *things not to do* because they may result in relapse. Drawing on all you have learned so far and on the experiences of others, please fill out the following.
- a. *Recovery activities*
- (1) What types of individual and/or group treatment sessions will I attend each week? When and where?
- _____
- _____
- (2) What support group meeting(s) will I attend during the week? When and where?
- _____
- _____
- (3) When, where, and for how long will I meet with my sponsor each week?
- _____
- b. *Creating a daily structure and routine*
- (1) What things will I do as part of my routine each day, and when will I do them?

(2) Each week?

(3) Each month?

- c. *Basic self-care.* When living compulsively, we often neglect the basics (e.g., eating a healthy diet, attending to medical needs, getting enough rest, getting healthy exercise). Building these into your life will increase your ability to cope with stress and to relieve stress when it occurs. What are some things you can do in each of the following areas to take care of yourself physically?

(1) Diet:

(2) Medical care:

(3) Rest:

(4) Exercise:

- d. *Relationships and support systems.* Relationships with loved ones and friends can have a tremendous effect on recovery, either helping or hurting. You will need to analyze past and current relationships and keep some in your life, end some, and develop some new relationships that support recovery.

(1) *Old relationships:* What relationships are likely to support your recovery, and what will you do to strengthen them?

What relationships will probably undermine your efforts, and how will you end or distance them?

- (2) *New relationships:* Where can you meet people to start some new, healthy, supportive relationships, and how will you go about finding them?

- (3) How you can get support from relationships: Please use this space to list names of people you feel you can talk to if you are feeling troubled, confused, or discouraged, and to write about how you will approach each of them to ask for this support.

Name

How I Will Ask for Support

- e. *Spirituality:* Whether you are religious or not, recovery involves making changes in your values and your goals in life, and people who have spiritual resources to support them are usually more successful in staying free of addictive thinking and behavior.

- (1) How will I address this component of my recovery?

- (2) What questions do I have about this, and whom can I ask for assistance?

- f. *Work:* Your job can be a major source of satisfaction, self-esteem, and security, but also a source of great stress, and recovering people are more likely than average to become workaholics, going overboard in responsibility, and burning themselves out.

- (1) What will I do to keep my work within healthy, moderate limits?

- (2) What will I do if something about my work is posing a risk to my recovery?

(3) How do I plan on dealing with stress related to work?

g. *Legal issues:* Dealing with the consequences of addictive behaviors is important to become a responsible person, reduce long-term stress, and gain self-respect.

(1) What am I doing to get any unfinished legal matters settled?

(2) What is one step I can take toward resolving these legal issues today (e.g., people to contact; appointments to make; resources needed)?

h. *Finances:* This is also another part of life that has great impact on self-esteem and stress levels. Many recovering people are intimidated by the financial problems they have when they first quit drinking, using, or otherwise behaving addictively, but find that with determined effort they are able to clear these difficulties up faster than expected.

(1) What financial problems do I have and what am I doing to resolve them?

(2) What is my long-term plan for financial stability?

(3) What is one step I can take today toward resolving these difficulties?

i. *Recreation:* Early recovery is a time to renew your involvement in activities you enjoyed in the past or start new activities that you always wanted to try. This will help you cope with stress and increase your enjoyment of life.

(1) What old healthy recreational activities will I take up again?

(2) What new activities will I try and/or am I interested in learning more about?

(3) What steps will I take to incorporate this into my weekly schedule?

(4) What is one step I will take today to work toward having fun?

j. *Other areas of life:*

(1) What other things do I see that I should focus on?

(2) What will I do to address these issues?

(3) What is one step I can take today to make progress on one of these issues?

8. *Crisis management.* Your plan needs to include steps to handle any crisis that might trigger a tendency to relapse. Please use this space to list the actions you will take to handle an unexpected (or expected) crisis without relapsing into addictive behavior.

9. *Things not to do because they may lead to relapse.* Finally, please use this space to list any activities you know you should carefully avoid. This may include going to certain places, seeing some people, or engaging in particular work or recreational activities.

Congratulations! You've created a foundation on which to build and a reference that will come in handy when you're under stress and having trouble thinking clearly. By completing this exercise, you've done much of that thinking in advance.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.